

RANBIR KAPOOR
AND KATRINA KAIF



RAAJNEETI

A dramatic update on the Mahabharata

- Ranbir Kapoor plays Arjun, an outsider who is forced to run a party, but does so on his own terms
- Katrina Kaif plays Draupadi, the widow of the Bhim-like elder brother, Arjun Rampal
- Nana Patekar plays Krishna, the mentor, while Manoj Bajpai plays Duryodhana, who believes the party belongs to him

RAAVAN

A retelling of the Ramayana

- Abhishek Bachchan plays Beera, the 'dus maathewala' anti-hero, Raavan
- Aishwarya Rai Bachchan plays the abducted wife, Sita
- Vikram is Dev, the upstanding police officer, who could also be Ram

AISHWARYA RAI BACHCHAN
AND ABHISHEK BACHCHAN



Ragini, who finds herself reciprocating. Shock. Horror. Err. A retelling of the Ramayana where Sita may reciprocate?

With *Raajneeti* bought by UTV for Rs 65 crore and *Raavan*'s three versions, in Hindi, Tamil and a Telugu dub, bought by Reliance Big Pictures for Rs 135 crore, it's likely to be an epic summer. Throw in the Rs 130-crore *Kites*, which will get a 2,300-screen release next week, and is a modern take on *Romeo and Juliet*, and our latter-day playwrights clearly fall short. And why not? Given that these epics are tattooed in our DNA. Sociologist Sanjay Srivastava points out that the Ramayana and Mahabharata themes have always been backdrops to Bollywood stories (selfless brothers, sacrificing mothers, dishonoured wives and warring clans are recurring themes). "What is new is the rediscovery of Indian tradition in an age of globalisation. At an earlier point, Hindi films had to show that 'we' are a 'modern' people, and hence any explicit invocation of religious texts would go against this. More recently, there is greater cultural confidence," he adds, which may be why the classic has

resurfaced, whether it is written by our own masters or that of the West.

The modernity of Hindi cinema today is one where Indian cultural texts are seen to be relevant to fresh narrative styles, whether it is the invoking of the Quran in *My Name is Khan* or the Mahabharata in *Raajneeti*. Add to it the edgy mood of Bollywood 2010, as it enters a summer of let's-take-a-risk-shall-we. Even Karan Johar's Dharma Productions is making a romantic comedy that takes the mickey of its own patented genre with the oddly spelt *I Hate Luv Storys* where Imran Khan plays a hard-boiled cynic assisting a Karan Johar-esque director and Sonam Kapoor plays a candyfloss-inspired production designer. Naturally, while one believes in love, the other doesn't.

And even when Bollywood plays a classic romance, it gets multicultural in the year's biggest release so far, Anurag Basu's *Kites*, which will get an additional 85 screens and counting in the US when its international version, edited by *Rush Hour* director Brett Ratner and Mark Helfrich, who edited *X-Men: The Last Stand*. The interna-

It's a summer where India will meet Bharat, where politics will offer entertainment, where literary texts may well translate into literal money.